ERA 3

Colonial America

1607 – 1754

Colonial regions · Chesapeake · New England · Middle · Southern

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

How did geography, motive, and labor systems create distinct colonial regions in British North America?

KEY TERMS

Jamestown · House of Burgesses · Puritans · Mayflower Compact · Quakers · cash crops · indentured servitude

ALIGNED TO

CED Topics 2.1–2.3 · AMSCO Ch. 2.1–2.3

SPAIN · FRANCE · THE NETHERLANDS · ENGLAND

Four Colonial Powers

Four Approaches to Colonization

Different goals produced very different colonies

POWER	GOAL	LABOR & SETTLEMENT	RELATIONS WITH NATIVES
Spain	Extract gold & silver; convert souls	**Encomienda**; few settlers, mostly men	Conquest & forced labor
France	Fur trade & profit	Few settlers; trading posts	Alliances & intermarriage
Netherlands	Trade & commerce	**New Amsterdam**; a trading hub	Trade partnerships
England	Farmland, profit & religious refuge	Many families; permanent farms	Displacement & conflict

New France



- Samuel de **Champlain** founded **Quebec** in 1608 as a fur-trading post.
- Few French settled—New France stayed sparsely populated.
- The French built strong **alliances** with Native nations through trade and intermarriage.

New Netherland

- The Dutch established **New Amsterdam** (later New York) as a trade center.
- Like the French, they prized commerce over large-scale settlement.
- Strong Native trade networks—but too few settlers to hold the colony.



SECTION

The Chesapeake Colonies

Jamestown, 1607



- The **Virginia Company** founded **Jamestown**—England's first permanent colony.
- Early years brought starvation and conflict; **John Smith**'s leadership barely saved it.
- **John Rolfe**'s **tobacco** became the cash crop that made Virginia profitable.

The Chesapeake Takes Shape

I

Tobacco & Labor

A **tobacco** economy powered by **indentured servants**, later enslaved Africans.

II

House of Burgesses

In 1619 Virginia created the first elected assembly in the colonies.

III

Maryland

Lord Baltimore founded a Catholic haven; the 1649 **Act of Toleration** protected Christian worship.

SECTION

The New England Colonies

The Puritans



- Led by **John Winthrop**, the **Puritans** built the **Massachusetts Bay** Colony.
- Winthrop called it a **"city upon a hill"**—a model Christian community.
- The **Great Migration** brought ~15,000 settlers in the 1630s.

Dissent Builds New Colonies

I

Roger Williams

Banished for his beliefs, he founded **Rhode Island** on religious freedom.

II

Anne Hutchinson

Exiled for challenging Puritan authority; she too settled in Rhode Island.

III

Thomas Hooker

Led settlers to **Connecticut** and its Fundamental Orders—an early written constitution.

SECTION

Southern & Middle Colonies

Two Very Different Regions

The Southern Colonies

Carolinas & Georgia

- Plantation economy of **rice** and **indigo**.
- Heavy reliance on enslaved African labor.
- **Georgia** founded as a buffer against Spanish Florida.

The Middle Colonies

NY · NJ · PA · DE

- The **"breadbasket"**—wheat and cereal crops.
- **William Penn**'s **Pennsylvania**: a Quaker haven of tolerance.
- The most ethnically and religiously diverse region.

The Four Regions Compared

Geography and labor shaped four distinct societies

REGION	ECONOMY	LABOR	SOCIETY & RELIGION
New England	Mixed: farming, fishing, trade	Family farms	**Puritan** towns; tight communities
Middle	"**Breadbasket**" grains, trade	Family farms & some servants	Diverse & tolerant
Chesapeake	**Tobacco**	Indentured, then enslaved	Scattered plantations
Southern	**Rice** & **indigo**	Enslaved Africans	Large plantations; hierarchy

SECTION

Roots of Self-Government

Seeds of American Democracy

Distance from Britain bred a habit of self-rule—for propertied white men

I

House of Burgesses

Virginia's 1619 assembly—the first representative government in the colonies.

II

Mayflower Compact

1620: Pilgrims pledged to govern by the will of the majority.

III

Town Meetings

New England towns governed themselves through direct participation.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

Colonial America

1. Spain, France, the Netherlands, and England pursued **different goals**—producing colonies built on conquest, trade, or settlement.

2. British North America split into **four distinct regions**—New England, Middle, Chesapeake, and Southern—shaped by geography and labor systems.

3. Distance from Britain bred early **self-government**—the **House of Burgesses**, **Mayflower Compact**, and town meetings—though rights stayed limited.

DISCUSS & APPLY

Colonial America

AP HISTORICAL REASONING PRACTICE

COMPARISON

Choose two colonial regions and explain how **environment and labor** produced very different societies.

CAUSATION

Explain how colonists' **motives** (profit, religious refuge, tolerance) caused distinct regional institutions.

CONTINUITY & CHANGE

How did colonial **self-government** both extend English traditions and depart from them?

Up next — **Lesson 4: Colonial Society** (Atlantic trade, slavery, self-government & the Great Awakening)